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Modelling Venetian Renaissance Writing: The Case of Veronica Franco

An introduction to Veronica Franco

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Veronica Franco (1546–1591)

- Renaissance poet, letter writer, and **cortigiana onesta**
- Humanist education and literary training
- Member of **Ca' Venier**, the leading literary salon of Venice
- Author of *Terze Rime* (1575) and *Lettere familiari a diversi* (1580)
- Writing as a strategy of **self-fashioning**, reputation, and cultural legitimacy



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Veronica Franco, *Letters* (1580)

- **Henry III** stayed in Venice in July 1574 while returning from Poland to France.
 - Veronica Franco dedicated to him a letter, two sonnets and her portrait.
 - The letter opens *Lettere familiari a diversi* (1580).
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- It functions as both a diplomatic dedication and a public statement of authorship.



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Venice after the plague (1575–1577)

- Courtesans occupied an ambiguous social position: admired, economically independent, yet morally contested.
- The plague transformed Venetian society, weakening patronage networks and increasing moral scrutiny.
- Veronica Franco lost relatives and experienced a decline in her social and economic position.
- The publication of *Lettere familiari a diversi* (1580) can be read as a deliberate act of rebranding.
- By turning private correspondence into a literary collection, Franco reshaped her public image from celebrated courtesan to respected author and intellectual.
- The opening letter to Henry III gives the collection prestige and political legitimacy.

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